Chapter Five - Double Bind

I began walking across the vast, endless plains of Vocaloid during my middle school years. Inside the costume of a "socially awkward and shy middle schooler," there lived another version of me—an Utaite who longed to deliver her songs to as many people as possible. Using every ounce of impulse hidden in my heart as fuel, I ran forward desperately, without even knowing where I was going.

When I sang, why did my body feel so light?
I felt a surge of confidence, believing I could sprint across those endless plains forever. If I kept this up, I could go anywhere.

But... every time I collided with a reality that didn't go my way, two voices echoed in my mind.
One was a bright voice saying, "You're so happy you can sing."
The other was an accusing voice asking, "Who do you even think you are?"

I wanted Ado to become an Utaite known by everyone. To achieve that, I felt that vocal technique alone wasn't enough; I needed to question myself about what kind of person I was and what I truly had to face.
"What am I, exactly?"
"How can I learn to like myself?"
"What will happen to me in the future?"

No matter how many times I asked, a simple answer never came.
Toward the end of my second year of middle school, I began to feel more and more that my innocent days were already over. The idea of becoming an adult started to frighten me. Someone like me could never become a decent adult. There was no way I could ever learn to love someone as useless as myself.
These negative thoughts spiraled in my head, binding my heart in tight shackles.

Looking back, there had been small distortions since the moment I entered middle school. In my school, it was mandatory for every student to join a club; I chose the art club. Back in elementary school, I had experienced the pain of having my illustrations thrown away by heartless classmates—a dull ache that remained with me—but I still loved drawing, and there was a faint hope that if I continued practicing in the art club, I might become better than I am now.

However, reality was slightly different. The seniors in the art club were arrogant simply because they were in higher grades, and many of them naturally spoke to their juniors in an ordering tone. A few weeks after joining, I began to feel a general sense of discomfort. Does a difference of just one year really mean that much? To me, the difference in birth year or date seemed like

such a trivial thing. Age alone shouldn't give someone the right to be arrogant, nor should it be a reason to look down on others.

I spent several months thinking these things, but the situation never changed. The seniors hardly ever drew; instead, they spent their time just chatting.

Before I knew it, I was the only one in the art club silently running her pencil across the paper. Without anyone showing their work or praising each other, I continued to draw while being treated as a weirdo. If I were going to draw alone, I could just do it at home. And if I drew at home, I could increase the time I spent singing in my closet. I gradually began to feel that the time spent on club activities was a waste.

Because I am poor at social interactions and cannot overlook things that lack logic or fairness, I became a "ghost member" of the art club after about six months.

Even so, school life was more enjoyable than it had been in elementary school. This was because I had four close friends in my class.
The time spent with them was a peaceful and happy interval. After school, we would gather at my house to play games, eat snacks, and occasionally go to karaoke. While leading the life of an ordinary middle school student like any other, every night I immersed myself deeply in the world of Vocaloid alone in my closet.

Every day, every hour, every minute, every second, I was struck by the dazzling brilliance of talent reflected on my computer screen, and I felt proud to be in a corner of that world.

However, the days I assumed would continue naturally began to quietly change shape.
By the time I entered my third year of middle school, I could no longer go to school. I became what is known as a *futōkō* (school refuser).

The trigger was the class reshuffling in the third year. I had been secretly looking forward to it with naive thoughts—wondering who among my four friends I would be in a class with, or perhaps all four of us would end up together again... but as it happened, I alone was placed in a separate class from the rest of them.

I was devastated, but even while crushed, reality does not change. In my own way, I tried to take action to fit into my new class. I found someone who had been in my class before and took a chance by speaking to them during break time. However, it always felt awkward; the conversations ended with mutual forced smiles.

I wondered if a transfer student might be different. A girl had transferred in on the day of the opening ceremony, so I thought this was my chance and spoke to her. But our tastes in manga, anime, and music didn't align at all. Even so, I tried to keep the conversation going, but I could tell by the look on her face that she felt slightly bothered. My heart withered once again.

My four friends from the other class tried to encourage me, saying things like, "You should just come visit our class," or "We can see each other at Ao's house after school anyway." While that was reassuring in its own way, the situation of being completely alone in my classroom was unbearably painful. I spent my days holding my breath in the classroom and eating my lunch in silence, moving my chopsticks mechanically. Although I told myself, "The third year has only just begun!" my heart had moved past pain and had begun to numb.

Then one morning, my feet froze at the front door of my house, and I could no longer go to school.
Worried that I could no longer attend middle school, my mother went to consult with my teachers. However, all she received from the principal and my homeroom teacher were words like, "Please find a way to make her attend."

After school, one of my friends came over to my house and told me:
"I heard a rumor that if your parents directly appealed to the teacher during the three-way parent-teacher conference before classes are announced, they can actually fix it."
Hearing this, I slumped in defeat, wondering, "Wait, there was a secret trick like that?"

My biggest anxiety after stopping school attendance was that I wouldn't be able to take my classes. To become a school refuser in the third year of middle school—the year when everyone is focused on high school entrance exams—felt catastrophic. I felt pathetic and spent countless hours silently weeping at home.

Worried, my mother consulted with the district board of education, and a few days later, I began attending the district's education center. I would go there at a set time, and under the supervision of the staff, I sat at a desk in a self-study space divided by partitions. One by one, I worked through the assignment sheets and workbooks sent from my school.

Any homework that wasn't finished had to be taken home. Once back home, I would first spread out the prints and finish the remaining problems.
Once everything was done, I drew pictures, watched Vocaloid on my computer, and recorded my own singing.

Even though I stopped attending school, my four friends continued to stop by my house several times a week. They would tell me about things that happened at school in their own voices: "This happened today," "I've progressed this far in my studies," or "We decided we're going to visit XX for our field trip."

After spending a few weeks like this, the school contacted us saying they desperately wanted me to return to class, and my mother...

My mother and I decided to go to school together. Apparently, we needed to take a new photo for my student ID and handle some paperwork regarding my future academic path.

Since I couldn't bring myself to enter the classroom, I went into the nurse's office. My mother was called away to the faculty room, leaving me alone with the school nurse. The teacher sat down beside me and spoke.

"Sawaki-san, why don't you try attending your next class today?"

Surprised that she would even suggest such a thing, I kept my face lowered and answered.

"...I'm sorry, I can't."

The teacher nodded understandingly, then raised her volume slightly.

"I don't think it's that you hate school, Sawaki-san. I think you just lack communication skills. That's why I feel we should try to support you a bit more."

I wondered where she had gotten this information from; I was shocked all over again to be labeled as "socially awkward" so definitively.

It was true that I might have poor communication skills. But even so, I didn't want a teacher I had spoken to only a handful of times to tell me to my face that my "communication skills were lacking." Just what did she think she knew about me?

As these thoughts began to swirl in my head, the grade level head teacher slid open the door to the nurse's office with a loud clatter.

The moment he saw my face, he let out a short sentence that echoed through the room.

"Hey! I listened to 'Ado'!"

I had heard previously that when this teacher asked one of my friends how I was doing, she had replied, "Ao posts videos under the name 'Ado'." I knew there was no malice in her words, and at the time, I had thought, *It's fine; it's not like a teacher would go out of his way to look me up.* And yet.

Ah, my precious world has been peeked into... While I sat there reeling from the damage, the teacher continued in a tone one might use to lecture a small child, completely oblivious to my expression.

"Listen, what's with that falsetto? If you're going to keep singing, you really need to work on extending your high notes."

What?

This teacher didn't teach music. He was the P.E. teacher. I had just been given a critique of my singing style by the gym teacher. At the moment, my reaction was a numb "Oh, is that so?" but as time passed, my heart began to ache. I had spent every single day diligently researching and refining my own way of singing. When I got home, I burst into tears and instinctively told my mother about it.

I know I'm overthinking it. I really do. But why do teachers feel the need to categorize me so easily? Why do they try to "correct" me? Words that were likely nothing more than a casual mutter to them resonated heavily within me, refusing to leave. Every time I felt that gap in perception, my heart tightened painfully.

Seeing me continue to cry, my mother called the grade level head teacher.

"What exactly did you mean when you told my Ao that she 'needs to extend her high notes'?"

In the next instant, my mother's voice rang out, sharp and piercing.

"The brass band club? What does that have to do with this child's singing!"

After hanging up, my mother shook her head, a deep frown etched between her brows.

"What... did he say?" I asked timidly. My mother's voice was saturated with anger.

"He said he was in the brass band back in his student days. He claimed that 'since I belonged to the brass band, I thought it would be best to offer some advice on vocalization.'"

When I grow up, there might come a day when I can look back and think, *Wow, that was hilarious.* It wasn't impossible to imagine such a future, but for me—whose mental state had been in shambles since the day classes were reshuffled—it was impossible to simply laugh it off.

Through these kinds of "incidents," my vague anxiety about "not being able to go to school" gradually transformed into a clear, definitive rejection: "I *don't want* to go to school."

Would I be able to graduate from middle school safely like this? Even if I did, would I be able to move on to high school? While sitting alone in the empty study space of the Education Center completing my assignments, a sense of panic seized me—a restlessness so intense I could hardly stay seated.

Around that time, I started attending a cram school to make up for the lessons I had missed. Almost every day, I talked with my mother about what to do regarding high school entrance exams. My mother would tell me, "At least make sure you graduate from high school," but for someone like me, who had fully committed to truancy, taking those exams was no easy feat.

In truth, I wanted to go to a high school that had a light music club so I could be in a band. Whenever I sang at home every day, I would think, *My parents might tell me I'm being noisy, but if I join the light music club in high school, I can sing as much as I want.* But after becoming a shut-in, my self-esteem was eroded bit by bit, and that dream vanished like a fragile mist.

Seeing how deeply depressed I had become, my mother said to me one day:

"Ao-chan, if you want to sing that badly, why don't you go to a training center or a vocational school with specialized courses for entertainment or music? You could just attend a correspondence high school for your diploma."

Oh, that's it! There's that option!

A sudden sense of exhilaration spread through me, like a rainbow appearing over my heart which had been drenched under dark clouds.

"Mom, thank you! I want to do that!"

When I told my father, he said casually, "If that's what Ao wants to do, then fine." But the words that followed made my heart shrink.

"I just can't provide the money for it."

My mother's voice immediately followed his.

"It's okay, it's okay. Ao-chan, don't worry about the money."

My father and mother didn't even look at each other, and the conversation ended there.

The cold atmosphere in this house wasn't just because of my truancy. The prickly emotions my parents occasionally displayed slowly drained away all the warmth. I returned to the closet in my room, put on my headphones, and stared at my favorite "Utattemita" videos like they were lucky charms, listening to them until the middle of the night.

Once Golden Week ended, I immediately began searching for training centers where I could study music professionally. Though I was anxious, imagining a future where I could sing filled me with a surge of energy that seemed impossible for a truant student. Since I wasn't going to school, I had plenty of time. At my mother's request, I started visiting these schools.

The second place I visited was an actors' school called "A." It was there that I met a wonderful teacher: Mr. Miyamoto.

After welcoming my mother and me for the orientation, Mr. Miyamoto listened carefully to our story and then spoke to me in a gentle voice.

"I see. So you love Vocaloids and sing every day. You truly love singing, don't you? That's wonderful, Ao-san."

In those words, I felt a genuine affection for music and an attitude of wanting to properly engage with the person standing before him. A sense of happiness flooded my chest—the feeling of having the things I loved accepted and understood head-on. To think there was a teacher who didn't view my love for Vocaloids as some kind of eccentricity, but instead listened with genuine interest.

Without hesitation, I made up my mind to apply for this actor's school.

Even though it was an entrance exam, since it was an actor's school, there were no age restrictions and applications were accepted at any time. There was no written academic test; instead, there were only a vocal performance, a self-promotion pitch, and an interview. I didn't have time to go find a professional teacher to learn from now, but since I sang every day, I told myself it would be fine... or at least, that's what I wanted to believe. The real problem was the interview.

I had never been through an interview in my life. I had heard that normally, classes would start practicing for high school entrance interviews around autumn, but I couldn't wait until then. I wanted to decide on a school where I could learn singing as quickly as possible and alleviate some of the anxiety regarding my future path.

Seeing me flustered over the thought of an interview, my mother called my junior high school to ask for advice. To my surprise, the principal himself promised to personally provide me with interview practice and guidance.

After that, I visited the school a few times after class to practice in the principal's office. I practiced opening the door, bowing before entering, sitting up straight in the chair, stating my name, and putting my feelings for singing into words. As I spoke to the principal over and over again, I reached a point where I actually looked forward to the actual interview.

"Sawaki-san, if you do exactly as we've practiced, you will certainly give a wonderful interview," the principal told me. His words sank quietly into my heart, which was swelling with anticipation.

Then came May 23, 2017—the day of the exam, two weeks later. My mother accompanied me but waited in a separate location away from the testing venue. From here on, I was alone.

First was the vocal test. The judges were Mr. Miyamoto and one other teacher. Once led into the room, I tapped the play button on my smartphone for "Strangers," a song by Vocaloid-P Heavenz. I faced the teachers.

I will sing this with all my heart.

Anxiety always leads the way
And in the city where an immature me arrived, before I knew it, there was only friction
Is that even necessary?
In a world where I was enclosed, what I defined as freedom
Was actually terrifying once I finally leaped out

Strangers
To us who are just counters on the other side of the screen
A question most unpleasant
Strangers
The grudge is "Doubt!"—that's how I screamed it

With that voice...

I noticed it, the essence and the origin
I understood it, long before now
"For someone else," "for myself"
Even so, you are—you are only you

Expectations always lead the way
And in the city where the immature me arrived, I merely skate across the surface
Words are just reflections
Dressing up and dressing up, wanting to be seen... but what I really want is for someone to see who I am inside
Even so, it permeates through, almost frighteningly

Strangers
We, who remain outsiders
Sometimes howl radically

Strangers
Let me hear your true will
With that voice...

I had kept these eyelids closed
But I was saved—though I intended to be the one giving
Even in solitude, even if laughed at
It reached you, it reached only you

Someone, someone—you must have been clinging to that thought
A voice enveloping me was just noise and I couldn't hear anything

Yet you were there, you were right there

For example, we who are like lost children
Were not alone.

This is a precious song for me; it sings of the cry of an outsider, a stranger, reaching only one person.

What if I fail because of this song? If this song—which reflects my own image exactly as it is—were to be rejected, I felt that I myself would be rejected. Carrying those thoughts while I sang, but when I finished, Mr. Miyamoto, who had been listening intently, gave me a slow and powerful round of applause.

Next was the self-promotion pitch. I was so happy about the applause that I couldn't immediately start speaking on the points I had prepared. I blinked a few times, steadied my breathing which had quickened after singing, and then spoke all at once.

"I love singing. The world of Vocaloid led me toward singing. I want to continue singing Vocaloid songs in the future. I have never been formally taught how to sing, but if I listen to a song a few times, I can memorize the melody and sing it. My strength is that I love singing, and that for something I love, I will spare no effort."

The moment I finished speaking my feelings, the tension left my shoulders. I recalled once more the words Mr. Miyamoto had said to me on the day I first visited the school: "You really do love singing, don't you?" I savored those words within myself again. Yes, I truly love singing; I love Vocaloid.

In the interview that followed, I was able to answer questions without being as nervous as I had imagined. Mr. Miyamoto and the other teacher asked me in a gentle tone about my relationship with music up until now, my favorite songs, and the world I wanted to aim for. Recalling the interview practice with my junior high school principal, I looked straight ahead and answered each question carefully.

"Thank you for your hard work today. We will contact you with the results in one week."

"Yes, I understand," I replied. Wrapped in a sense of satisfaction that I had given it my all, I bowed deeply.

While my classmates were diligently practicing for the spring sports day, I was taking an entrance exam for the Actors School and waiting for the results. I couldn't do the same things as they did, but by summoning every ounce of courage I possessed, I felt that I was moving forward, little by little, at my own pace.

A notification of acceptance from the Actors School arrived on my mother's smartphone. My mother, with tears brimming in the corners of her eyes, let out a trembling voice as she rejoiced, "Thank goodness, you passed! You really made it!" We instinctively threw our arms around each other.

Along with the Actors School, I also decided on a correspondence high school. Once I submitted my application and confirmed that I would definitely be admitted as long as I graduated from middle school, a profound sense of relief washed over me. Until then, every day had been an agonizing struggle; I felt crushed by anxiety surrounding my future path and graduation, often feeling miserable, depressed, and on the verge of tears. However, once the worry about my education was resolved, my heart felt lighter, and it seemed as though the world in front of me grew a bit brighter.

Yet, even after my path was decided, I still couldn't bring myself to attend school. Even when handwritten letters from the nurse arrived along with the handouts, I was too terrified to even open them.

The very idea of "school" had become something far too distant for me.

One day, as graduation approached, a final assignment arrived from my middle school. It was an essay on the theme: "Reflections toward Graduation." Since I had been liberated from the anxiety of moving forward, I began to write, stirring up my heart and dredging up even the sediment that had sunk to the very bottom of my soul.

The title of my essay was "Middle School."

I hate school.

It is a cycle of always being bound by something, being taught something, and being scolded. Over and over again.

What exactly was it that bound me?

On those mornings, what was it that clung to my legs, robbing me of the strength to head toward the classroom?

A class without friends, awkward conversations, the sight of a teacher shouting in anger. All of these seemed to be the cause, yet none of them felt like the definitive answer.

I have seen you say things like: "Why can't you do it?! Why are you all so useless without a teacher?! This class is hopeless!"

So please, tell me what exactly is "hopeless." What is the point in making the students think about it themselves? You compare your own class to others and speak only of the flaws of your own students. This is the exact thing that students hate most. To not even realize this—are you truly a teacher?

No one, I believe, started out as that kind of person.

Adults who push their own emotions onto others and lecture them without ever listening to the feelings of the students. No matter how much I thought about it, I could never understand why they became that way.

But one thing is clear.

I do not want to become an adult like those who hurled heartless words at me back then.

I want to ensure that I absolutely never become a person who tramples on the feelings of others.

To keep my thoughts from spilling over, I gripped my pencil tighter and let it race across the paper.

It didn't matter if the words were clumsy. I wanted to leave a permanent record of exactly how I felt in this very moment.

"Have you been told by various people that your dreams are foolish, or that you can't do it? Have you accepted those words as truth and allowed yourself to be stopped here? You aren't at worst; no one is truly at fault. What matters is changing the way you think."

"You cannot change others. So why not just change your own perspective and how you receive things? That is what is important. Otherwise, you will only continue to bind the wings of your students, and they will end up just like you."

As I wrote, the harsh words directed at my teacher shifted, almost without me to notice, into words of encouragement for "someone."

"Let's have wonderful dreams. To make your art reach the world. To teach children across the country that soccer is wonderful. To brighten everyone's mood with your comedy. Anything is fine. One person's dream becomes a shared dream, and when they all gather, they form a great path forward. So please, you too, have a dream."

"I also have a dream, of course. To connect with everyone on the internet, and for the songs I sing to reach the world. To release CDs and hold live concerts—and to do it through the power

of the internet. It's fine if people think it's stupid. Everyone is different. It's just like human personality."

"The 'internet' I am talking about is something called Niconico Dōga. Do you think it's only for otaku? You're wrong. There is love there. Please, listen to a song called *Painter*. I recommend watching it on Niconico Dōga; so many dreams are gathered there."

"And please look at the lyrics. Those lyrics are based on what I have written here. If you read this and feel whatever you feels, that's your freedom. But if even one person empathizes or is moved by this, then that is enough for me."

The text tumbled forward, a clumsy mixture of anger toward middle school and the passion for my dreams. Even so, it was fine. I would write it all out. In the end, I wrote these words and set down my pencil:

I want to keep holding onto my dreams, and I want to make this life an enjoyable one.

In the end, I continued attending the education center until the end of the third term. When graduation came, the principal and vice-principal decided to hold a graduation ceremony just for me.

I was led into a private room separate from the usual self-study space. It was a small meeting room with wooden desks and chairs, a whiteboard against the wall, and a shelf. The principal, the vice-principal, and a staff member from the education center were inside; they gave a quiet nod as I entered. My graduation certificate sat softly on the desk.

The principal called my name and carefully read the certificate aloud before handing it to me. Afterward, he looked straight into my eyes and bowed deeply.

"Sawaki-san, I read that essay. I am sorry we could not create an environment where you could attend school happily."

"No, it's not like that... I'm the one who should be sorry..."

Thinking of adults like the principal who had treated me well, a wave of guilt washed over me for having written the essay in such an emotional outburst.

Please don't apologize. Even though I poured my heart out so violently in that essay, I know that not being able to go to school was a problem with myself—that I couldn't fit in with those around me... or rather, that I didn't try to fit in. It was just that I wasn't good at making friends. I simply felt sorry for my own circumstances and turned my back on school.

I didn't know what to say, so I bowed my head just as deeply as the principal had.

And so, watched over by the staff of the education center, my solitary graduation ceremony ended in about ten minutes. I said a final goodbye to my middle school years.

From now on, a new world awaits me. By going to the Actors School, I can get closer to the person I want to become. Finally, I have grasped the chance to make my dreams come true.

The middle school graduation certificate felt like a ticket to the future—one that I had snatched away by clinging desperately to reality. The destination was still unclear, but I felt as though I could go somewhere far brighter than where I am now.

Having passed the entrance exams for both the Actors School and a correspondence high school, I was prepared to plunge into busy days of balancing music and academics. I planned to study at home and graduate from the correspondence high school within three years without fail. Meanwhile, at the Actors School, I would take lessons five days a week to formally learn singing and acquire skills in dance and songwriting. My dream of posting videos on Niconico Dōga and becoming an Utaite known by everyone had expanded far beyond anything it had been before.

The days I desired—the days I prayed for—were supposed to start in April. And yet... I realized something.

What was binding my heart were people who were much closer to me than my school teachers.

I wanted to live freely. To reclaim that simple, obvious wish, I decided to trace back through my memories as if rewinding time and face myself. I recalled the same scenes over and over again, verifying them.

What is it that binds my heart and robs me of my freedom? Who is it?

Finally, I discovered its true identity.

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When I was young, I was a child who never suppressed her emotions. This was because of my parents' educational philosophy. The stance of granting Ao free will apparently stemmed from a parenting book my father had read. My father became devoted to this single volume and decided to raise me exactly according to the teachings within it.

For example, if a child threw a fit because they didn’t want to go to kindergarten, a typical parent would force them by the hand and take them there; however, that would mean being forced by the parent—the person the child trusts most. Therefore, one must never use parental authority to make a child obey.

My mother also empathized with the contents of that book and did not oppose my father's educational policy. Although she apparently felt a flicker of anxiety about me quitting kindergarten, in the end, she trusted what was written in the parenting book and stopped sending me there—a fact I only learned after I had entered middle school.

Until I started elementary school, I absolutely loved my father; to the point where I felt that as long as I had him, I didn't need my mother. Of course, there were circumstances: my mother worked often to support our lives and was rarely home, while the time I spent with my father was overwhelmingly longer. At the time, I mistakenly believed that the length of time we spent together equaled affection.

Back then, we had a pet dog, and it was always my mother who took care of it. My mother truly adored that dog, petting it affectionately and always talking to it. Unlike me, the dog didn't talk back and accepted affection obediently. Because of this, even as a child, I felt that my mother probably liked the dog more than me. Whenever the dog was by my mother's side, I felt for some reason that I shouldn't get in the way, so I

stepped back and kept my distance.

While doing so, I gradually began to think: maybe my mother doesn't love me as much as my father does. In response to such thoughts, my mother would always nag me.

"Doing things you like isn't painful. But people have things they must do, even if it's painful or boring. Ao-chan, right now, you are only facing the things that bring you pleasure. That's why I'm worried. You can't survive in life on pleasant things alone."

Looking back now, I think my mother then was worried about my future—wondering if I was being spoiled too much by my father or if I would be okay later on since I was living a life so far removed from the children my own age at school or in the neighborhood. It was likely nagged out of that concern.

After I became an adult, my mother once told me, "Ao-chan was patient and observant, a child who could be considerate of others." However, there is a slight gap between that and my memory.

I struggled with being assertive. At school, while I was talking to a friend, it often happened that another child would come along, start talking to the friend, and lead them away. In those moments, I couldn't say, "Hey! I'm talking to her right now!" Instead, I thought in my heart, *Well, I guess she prefers that person,* and I had no choice but to trudge back home alone.

I find it emotionally easier to yield rather than to fight with someone over something. That has remained unchanged since childhood.

In elementary school, my pencils were often taken by friends. To be precise, in my mind, I didn't have the sense that they were "taken." I simply felt we had "exchanged" my cute pencil with a charm on it for a friend's ordinary pencil.

However, my mother, seeing this, spoke to me as if pitying me.

"Ao-chan is too nice, that's why these things happen to you."

My mother's shop sold many cute stationery items, so I knew the other children were targeting those. But I thought, *It's okay; when I go home, my mother will give me more,* and I "exchanged" them as they begged me.

One day, upon returning home, my mother looked at my pencil case and asked in surprise.

"What happened? We don't sell these kinds of pencils at home."

"A friend asked to trade, so I traded with them."

I hadn't been subjected to violence or had things broken; if the other child was happy, then I thought that was enough. My feeling was something like: *Wow, they're so happy with my thing, how wonderful.*

But at that time, my mother snapped at me in a voice lower than usual.

"Oh, for heaven's sake, Ao-chan is truly too easy to take advantage of."

Even if it was just small stationery items, seeing her daughter being robbed of things must have been unbearable for her.

However, those words were like a sharp blade, slicing through my tiny joy.

My mother always said as a habit:

"Ao-chan is clumsy and can't do anything."

"Ao-chan is such a princess."

Those might have been meaningless words to my mother. But to me as a child, each word felt like a stake driven into my chest.

Sometimes, she would add with a hint of reflection, "Maybe I was too overprotective." She always anticipated everything—because it was dangerous, because it was difficult, or because it took too long—and even the ribbon tie for my shoelaces, my mother tied them before I ever

learned how to do it. In that way, my childhood life was a repetition of "ending before I could become capable."

Because of that influence, as I grew up, every time I tried to do something, a small voice would echo in my head: *I'm no good,* *I'm clumsy anyway,* *This isn't for me after {the}*...

Eventually, that voice turned into chains that bound my actions.

Gradually, I became hypersensitive to my parents' words. Every time my mother gave me advice like "Why don't you try it this way?", my body would freeze for a moment. *Ao-chan, that's no good. See, you can't do it after all. It's better to do it this way.* Any word felt like a denial of myself, and I would shrink back again.

That is why I hated the idea of my parents seeing me sing.

Because it was unbearably embarrassing for "the me who could do nothing" to be seen "doing something."

"We don't have any money." Whenever I search through my earliest memories, the first thing that comes to mind is the sight of my mother's back as she worked. After marriage, she never stopped working; she was busy day and night just to keep our household afloat. My father, on the other hand, spent most of his time at home, occasionally drifting away to wherever he pleased.

Every time I heard her let those words slip, a tightening anxiety gripped my chest. What if I couldn't go to school anymore? What if our lives completely fell apart? Even as a child, I felt the crushing weight of reality and there were nights when I was so worried that I couldn't sleep.

My mother was desperate. To earn a living, she started a small business from home, lining up cosmetics and stationery and greeting every single customer with a smile. In her profile, I could see both exhaustion and a fierce determination.

Compared to her, my father had periods where he worked, but for the most part, he relied entirely on her. As a young child, I couldn't yet connect those images to a word like "pathetic," but looking back now, I think that was when the distortions in our family began to form.

By the time I reached the upper grades of elementary school, the sound of my drunken father and my mother—fresh from work—arguing would echo through every corner of the house. I felt it instinctively as a child: poverty erodes the human heart and can even destroy the bonds of a family. Since I wasn't particularly good at studying, I couldn't imagine a future where I went to university and became some kind of elite; instead, I fell asleep every night praying that I would grow up quickly so I could earn money with my own strength.

My parents began to struggle with their monthly living expenses, and they fought violently over the smallest triggers. Because the three of us lived in a cramped house, their shouting matched the volume of the entire home. The way they addressed each other shifted from "Dad" and "Mom" to "You," accompanied by the frequent sound of glasses being slammed onto the living room table with a crash, interspersed with raw, aggressive verbal abuse. That sound—loud enough to make the windowpanes vibrate—stayed in my ears forever.

Whenever I couldn't bear that atmosphere anymore, I would put on my headphones, blast Vocaloid songs at full volume, and dive under my covers, simply waiting for time to pass while praying for it all to end quickly.

If these two hadn't married, I wouldn't have been born. These two wouldn't have had to hurt each other like this. While surrendering my heart to the Vocaloid sounds in my ears, those thoughts would quietly surface; no matter how hard I tried to push them away, they wouldn't disappear. And in the end, it always led me back to blaming my own existence as Ao Sawaki.

The breaking point of their fights was always "divorce." Every time I heard those three letters—"di-vorce"—I trembled with fear. As a powerless child, there was no way I could make a decision about whose life I should follow. The terror that everything in my environment would change instantly if my parents separated cast a shadow over my daily life.

Even after I entered middle school, the fighting continued. Having reached adolescence, I could no longer tolerate the shouting; several times, I stepped in between them to try and stop it.

I once sent long strings of LINE messages to both my father and mother, intentionally using formal language, asking "Why are you fighting?" and "Why did you even get married?" I wanted them to know that even through a single wall, the arguments were perfectly audible. Even so, they didn't stop. No matter how much I continued messaging them while crying, neither my father nor my mother ever replied.

Then, the house turned into hell. On one day when their fighting was as loud and flamboyant as it could possibly be, I walked from my room toward the living room where they were arguing. Because I had been crying non-stop, my body felt drained of strength; I approached them almost crawling on the floor. But even seeing me in that state, neither my father nor my mother moved.

In a drama, if a child cries and screams "Stop it already!" in front of fighting parents, everything is supposed to resolve peacefully. Reality isn't that sweet. Neither of them rushed to my side as I crawled there, nor did they say, "I'm sorry, we won't fight anymore." My existence was not a reason for them to stop.

When the two finally finished their argument, they returned to their respective spaces. My father to the living room sofa, my mother leaving the kitchen for the bedroom. When it finally became

quiet, my father looked at me with desolate eyes, but he never tried to apologize. He muttered a single "Sorry," but he would never actually apologize to my mother.

Looking toward the kitchen with an unsettled heart, I saw that the pasta dinner my mother had made sat untouched in the trash can. My father must have thrown it away. The red of the meat sauce clinging to the plastic bag burned into the back of my eyes and wouldn't leave me.

From then on, I became hypersensitive to every sound in the house. The sound of my father slamming a glass onto the table, the sound of my mother closing a door slightly too hard—every time a noise echoed through the home, I remained on high alert.

Especially while they were talking, I would shrink myself and keep praying that a fight wouldn't break out. When I heard the sounds of them laughing together while watching TV, I felt such relief that I couldn't help but pray that days like this would last forever.

Without realizing it, I developed a habit of blaming everything on myself. The lack of money, the discord between my father and mother—it must all be because of me. It had to be.

It was around this time that I clearly realized I hated myself. My shoulders would flinch at my parents' words; my heart would freeze, and the air would suddenly turn cold. Wrapped in a suffocating discomfort, I was slowly swallowed by thoughts like "This is happening because I'm useless" and "I hate myself."

What comforted my heart during this period of self-blame were Hatsune Miku, Ugoiku Memochō, Vocaloid-Ps, and Utaites. On the other side of the screen, someone was composing a song, someone was singing, someone was drawing an illustration, and together they were expanding a wonderful world. Without exaggeration, their existence was my lifeline.

When my father was in a good mood, he would brag—as if it were some kind of medal—about how he had played Western music for me since before I could even speak.

"With my gifted education, Ao became great at singing."
"Ao is amazing; she's a genius. She might win the Japan Record Award one day. No, even a Grammy isn't out of the question."

My mother would brush it off with a light "That's just a parent's bias," but my father continued to repeat those things with satisfaction. He acted as if he were asserting that he was the one who discovered and nurtured Ao's singing talent.

Every time, I muttered in my heart, *Oh, here we go again,* feeling utterly exhausted. I had a vague sense that my father was secretly listening to me sing inside the closet. However, there was never once a moment where I wanted him to listen. I sang alone in the closet, carrying a constant tension, knowing that I might be overheard.

I am certainly grateful that he let me touch a computer at a young age. Without a computer, I wouldn't have even been able to encounter Vocaloid songs. But my obsession with Vocaloid culture wasn't the result of someone guiding me. I followed tags, encountered songs in a vast ocean-like world that made my heart race, and traced their melodies. Those are treasures that I earned for myself.

By the time I entered middle school, my father began to treat me as if I were his property, using his words and attitude to bind me...

And so it went. In particular, the negativity toward my "singing" only grew more intense.

Late at night, smelling of alcohol and slurring his words, he would come to my room and vent his frustrations upon me. I would huddle inside my closet, listening to him as I shrank away.

"What on earth is that singing? Listen to proper songs, and sing proper songs."

"No one in the entertainment industry would ever recognize something like that."

"You aren't utilizing your vocal ability at all. Can you even call a song like this music?"

Perhaps my silence—the way I just let his words wash over me without responding—irritated him further, because eventually, he stopped complaining about the songs themselves and began attacking my "style of singing."

"What is with that scratchy, distorted way of singing?"

"Don't sing with such a growl. If you keep making sounds like that, one day you won't be able to sing at all."

The forms of expression I had found through countless trials and errors—the style I had discovered for myself—were flatly denied by my father.

"And listen, if you keep singing like that, you'll end up just like me."

Apparently, my father used to be a vocalist in a band and once dreamed of entering the entertainment world. But he never made it as a professional, and he was likely still dragging around the bitterness of that failure.

His verbal abuse grew more violent with each passing day.

Even when I tried to escape into my room to be alone, it meant nothing in a house where the doors didn't lock. One night, my father flung my door open with a loud crash and showered me with screams.

"Stop this right now. If you don't stop, I will forbid you from singing entirely!"

My beloved Vocaloids and my challenge of creating "Utattemita" videos. For someone like me who had stopped attending school, it was the act of singing that allowed me to keep living without giving up on the future. Was he really intending to strip away that precious world from me?

Rather than fear, a deep, slow-spreading sadness washed over me. To survive the moment, I had no choice but to repeat "Yes, yes," and wait for the storm to pass.

Eventually, my father's negativity toward me crossed a line that could no longer be forgiven.

One day, while cleaning my room, I happened to be organizing my bookshelf.

Lined up on the shelf were biographical manga about people like Coco Chanel, Helen Keller, and Walt Disney. It was a favorite series of mine; I had read them over and over again since my father bought them for me when I was in elementary school.

From the moment I could remember, my father had constantly told me, "Read books, read books." Because he spent so much time reading to me as a child, I should have loved books, but because he continued to nag me about it incessantly even as I grew older, it felt as though countless tiny thorns were being driven into my heart.

As I sat before the bookshelf, recalling that pain with bitterness and tracing the covers of the books with my fingertips, my father barged into the room again without so much as a knock. He snatched the book from my hand and screamed at me with terrifying intensity.

"Ridiculous! Reading things like this is why you're becoming useless!"

My entire body stiffened; my breath stopped.

Why... how could he even think that?

Just as I asked myself that, more words flew at me, piling on the attack.

"I know the best songs and the best way to sing for you, Ao. If you listen to me, you can become a professional singer one day. So shut up and do as you're told!"

With those words, something precious inside of me collapsed with a loud crash. No matter how constant our clashes had been, the happy memories of my childhood and our blood connection had barely managed to keep the bond between parent and child intact. The atmosphere that once felt warm—like a place where I belonged—shattered in that instant into pieces that could never be put back together.

Ah, this man.

He just wants to turn my dream into his own achievement.

He just wants to paint over my life with his own ideas.

I have to protect my world by myself.

"…Ado is no one's property."

I stated it clearly. It was not the usual voice I used when trying to appease my parents' moods.

"You might be my father, but I am the one who raised Ado. She is an existence I grew with my own strength and hard work. She wasn't born just so you could order me around."

My father's eyes widened. His screams rushed toward me.

"How dare you speak to me like that! I only did this for your sake—"

"No!!!"

I screamed back reflexively. Everything that had been bottled up in the depths of my heart finally erupted.

"…Ado is free. No one should be able to constrain or dominate her."

The screaming started again. But now, it no longer sounded like words; it was nothing more than noise.

My father—a man who loved me unconditionally and yet was so overprotective that it felt suffocating.

You're wrong. The "Ao" you want is not the real "Ao."

Love and restraint. Claiming it was "for my sake" while refusing to acknowledge my own will. I vowed in my heart that I would fight with everything I had against this double bind—this attempt by my father to mold both Ao and Ado into exactly what he wanted.
I will not let my singing or my life become someone else's possession. I will protect "Ado" until the end, with these hands of mine.